Between the 1860s and 1880s, a single system of global trade had emerged—a process accelerated by the opening of the Suez Canal in 1869. Commodities could now reach the farthest markets across the world.[21] Parallel to this trade was the great migration: in the century between 1840 and 1940, nearly 30 million people left Indian shores from the eastern seaboard, with eight million travelling to Ceylon (Sri Lanka).[22] In his magisterial history of migration in the Bay of Bengal area, Sunil Amrith demonstrates that the last quarter of the nineteenth century was pivotal with 'the slow intensification of "traffic"'.[23] 'The great truck highway', which ran via Bombay, Colombo and Rangoon, connected Europe and Asia, and Tuticorin was a dot on this route.[24]

If steamships moved cargo and people, telegraph conveyed information in almost real time.[25] This revolution in communication technology closely monitored the global movement of ships and enabled the registering of data by classification societies such as the Lloyd's Register of Shipping and Bureau Veritas, an invaluable source of information for merchants, insurers, etc.

As a result, by the late nineteenth century, shipping had—as a contemporary marine historian noted colourfully—turned from a high-risk business into a lucrative enterprise with high reliability.

> The modern steamer voyage can be estimated to within a couple of days; coasts and seas are well surveyed. No French privateers are known to be cruising in Indian seas; no lurking pirates, English, cosmopolitan, Arab, Seedee, or Mahratta, will sally forth to attack his ship; guns are unnecessary. A telegram precedes his arrival; the cargo is often sold and resold before he arrives at his destination. His plumed hat has given place to the prosaic solar topee; his sharp sword has degenerated into the harmless walking-stick … [26]

Formed in the 1830s, the Peninsular and Oriental Steam Navigation Company (P&O) had, within a decade, taken the Indian Ocean trade in its grip. A decade or so later, the British India Steam Navigation Company joined the fray, becoming, in the words of its official chronicler, 'one of the largest shipping concerns in the world'. '[K]nown everywhere as "the